whose descendants can still be found in Madurai, Tirunelveli, Coimbatore, North Arcot and in the Nilgiris.

These Mussulman Mappilas were soon established along India's western seaboard as traders in spices and pearls, and as seamen and cavalrymen. The Islam they brought with them was inclusive and accommodating, very much in harmony with the theistic bhakti cult that was at this time emerging within early medieval Hinduism. To this day some Mappila mosques still incorporate what some more orthodox Sunni Muslims would consider to be unIslamic practices, suggesting that in earlier times their predecessors sought to fit in with their new environment.

Similarly, images of Kamadhenu, the wish-fulfilling cow widely venerated among Hindus, often show her with a crowned human female face and a peacock's tail, which some art historians attribute to the influence of popular Shia images of Al-Buraq, the heavenly steed upon which the Prophet made his famous night-time journey from Mecca to Jerusalem. But it might equally be the other way round. Either way, both creatures are much beloved as talismans of their respective faiths.[1]

Islam won many converts in South India among the downtrodden. Islam's egalitarian nature offered an escape from the rigid social order of orthodox Hinduism, and not only in the South. The British civil servant and historian William Hunter spent many years in Bengal in the middle decades of the nineteenth century and was one of the first Englishmen to write sympathetically about the impact of Islam on India, and what he had to say about conversions in Bengal can equally be applied to other parts of India. 'It was not to force that Islam owed its permanent success (in Lower Bengal),' he declared. 'It appealed to the people, and it derived the great mass of its converts from the poor. It brought in a higher conception of God, and a nobler idea of the brotherhood of man. It offered to the teeming low